

Excommunication As Final Step

prc-excommunication-as-final-step

Church Discipline · Discipline Process · practice · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Excommunication (removal from fellowship and the Lord's Table) is the final step of the Matthew 18 process for unrepentant sin, intended to provoke repentance and protect the assembly.

In plain language

The words in these passages point the same direction. In Matthew 18 Jesus lays out a clear sequence: first a private word, then one or two witnesses, then the gathered assembly (ekklesia, the called-out community), and only if the person refuses to hear (parakouo) even the assembly is he to be treated as an outsider, like a Gentile (ethnikos) or a tax collector (telones). The grammar marks each stage as conditional (an 'if-then' clause) on the previous one failing, so this is plainly the last stage, not the first. In 1 Corinthians 5 Paul issues a sharp command: 'remove the evil one from among yourselves' (exairo). The verb he uses for remove appears only this once in the Greek New Testament (a hapax, a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so its meaning is read from the repeated Old Testament formula it echoes, 'purge the evil from your midst', found again and again in Deuteronomy. Paul says what removal means in practice: do not keep company with such a person (synanamignymi), and do not even share a meal, which withdraws table fellowship. Two reasons sit plainly in the text. First, protection: a little leaven (zyme, a figure for spreading corruption) leavens the whole lump, so the action guards the body from spreading corruption. Second, restoration: the offender is handed over (paradidomi) so that the spirit may be saved, and in 2 Thessalonians 3 the separation is done so that he may be ashamed (entrepo) and turn back, while still being admonished (noutheteo) as a brother and not treated as an enemy. The same restorative aim appears in 1 Timothy 1:20 and in Titus 3:10, where a divisive person is rejected (paraiteomai) only after a first and second warning. So across a gospel and several letters one pattern holds: a final step taken after lesser efforts fail, carried out by the gathered community against one of its own, aimed both at guarding the assembly and at recovering the person. Where readers can diverge is narrow. The words give two vivid scenes of escalation but do not spell out one fixed universal procedure, and they make removal final in the disciplinary process while leaving the door to repentance and return open, not a permanent banishment.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0080	ἀδελφός	adelphos	brother	
G0727	ἄρπαξ	harpax	rapacious	
G1482	ἐθνικός	ethnikos	Gentile-like	4
G1496	εἰδωλολάτρης	eidōlōlatrēs	idolater	
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklesia	assembly	115
G1788	ἐντρέπω	entrepo	to cause shame	9
G1808	ἐξαίρω	exairo	to expel	1

G2219	ζύμη	zyme	leaven	13
G2919	κρίνω	krinō	to judge	
G3366	μηδέ	mēde	nor	
G3560	νουθετέω	noutheteo	to admonish	8
G3860	παραδίδωμι	paradidomi	to deliver	121
G3868	παραίτεομαι	paraiteomai	to refuse/excuse	12
G3878	παρακούω	parakouo	to ignore	3
G4205	πόρνος	pornos	sexual sinner	10
G4593	σημειώω	sēmeioō	to note	
G4874	συναναμίγνυμι	synanamignymi	to associate with	3
G5057	τελώνης	telones	tax collector	21

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Three converging strands of word evidence carry the proposition. Matthew 18:15-17 is openly step-by-step: a private word, then with witnesses, then the gathered assembly, with the result clause 'let him be to you as the Gentile and the tax collector' (esto soi hospes ho ethnikos kai ho telones) made conditional on 'if he refuses to hear even the assembly' (ean de parakouse tes ekklesias), so treating him as an outsider is the final tier. The verb that commands removal in 1 Corinthians 5:13, 'remove' (exarate), is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the Greek New Testament, so its force is established not from New Testament spread but from the repeated Hebrew expulsion formula behind it (Deuteronomy 17:7; 19:19; 21:21; 22:21,24; 24:7, 'purge the evil from your midst'), all present in the corpus. 1 Corinthians 5:11 spells out the removal as 'do not associate' (me synanamignysthai) and 'do not even eat together' (mede synesthiein), withdrawing table fellowship. The purpose is stated in the text: protection (1 Corinthians 5:6, 'a little leaven leavens the whole lump') and restoration (the 'so that' purpose clauses (hina clauses) of 1 Corinthians 5:5 'that the spirit may be saved' (to pneuma sothe), 2 Thessalonians 3:14 'that he may be put to shame' (hina entrape), 1 Timothy 1:20 'that they may be disciplined' (hina paideuthosi)). The vocabulary supports both the final ordering and the dual aim the proposition asserts.

Scripture

Matt.18.15 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The 'if' part of the if-then sentence (the protasis), 'if your brother sins against you' (ean de hamartese eis se ho adelphos sou), opens a graded procedure: 'go and reprove him between you and him alone' (hypage elegxon auton metaxy sou kai autou monou). This first private tier is explicit in the words and establishes that what follows is a sequence, not a single isolated act.

Matt.18.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3878 παρακούω

Reasoning. The 'if-then' clause (conditional) 'but if he does not listen' (ean de me akouse) moves on to 'take with you one or two more' (paralabe meta sou eti hena e duo), citing the two-or-three-witnesses rule. The second tier is named in the grammar, confirming an escalating order before the assembly is involved.

Matt.18.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G1482 ἔθνικός

Reasoning. The third tier 'tell it to the assembly' (eipon te ekklesia), then the 'if-then' clause (conditional) 'if he refuses to hear even the assembly' (ean de kai tes ekklesias parakouse) yields the result clause 'let him be to you as the Gentile and the tax collector' (esto soi hosper ho ethnikos kai ho telones). The verb 'refuse to listen' (parakouo) is rare (3 occurrences, twice here) but its sense, refuse to listen, is fixed by the immediate contrast with 'hear' (akouo) in 18:15-16, and 'Gentile' (ethnikos) (4 occurrences, all marking an outsider) sets the disciplined one outside the community. This is the final tier of the sequence.

1Cor.5.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1808 ἐξαίρω, G2919 κρίνω

Reasoning. The command form 'remove the evil person from among yourselves' (exarate ton poneron ex hymon auton) uses 'remove' (exairo), which occurs only here in the Greek New Testament. Because it is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) its sense is read from the repeated Hebrew expulsion formula it reproduces, 'purge the evil from your midst' (Deuteronomy 17:7; 19:19; 21:21; 22:21,24; 24:7). The neighboring contrast 'God judges those outside' (tous exo ho theos krinei) against the assembly judging 'those inside' (tous eso) places the removal squarely within the gathered community.

1Cor.5.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3860 παραδίδωμι

Reasoning. The verb form 'to hand such a one over to Satan' (paradounai ton toiouton to Satana) governs the purpose clause 'that the spirit may be saved in the day of the Lord' (hina to pneuma sothe en te hemera tou kyriou). 'Hand over' (paradidomi) is a common verb (121 occurrences) meaning hand over or deliver up, so the disciplinary sense here is supplied by its object, to Satan, and the saving 'so that' clause (the hina clause, a 'so that' purpose clause) makes the handover restorative in aim, not merely punitive.

1Cor.5.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4874 συναναμίγνυμι, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The directive 'do not keep company with' (me synanamignysthai), applied to a so-called brother who persists in named sins, is intensified by the climactic 'with such a one not even to eat' (to toiouto mede synesthiein). 'Keep company with' (synanamignymi) occurs only three times (here, 5:9, and 2 Thessalonians 3:14), each time of disciplinary social separation, so the sense is stable across its small distribution. The withdrawal of shared table fellowship is the concrete content of the removal commanded in 5:13.

1Cor.5.7 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2219 ζύμη

Reasoning. The command 'cleanse out the old leaven' (ekkatharate ten palaian zymen), with the explanatory 'a little leaven leavens the whole lump' (mikra zyme holon to phyrama zymoi) (5:6), supplies the protective rationale. 'Leaven' (zyme) carries a stable figurative sense of pervasive corrupting influence across its 13 occurrences in the Synoptic Gospels and Paul. Removal guards the gathered body from corruption spreading, the 'protect the assembly' element of the proposition.

2Thess.3.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4874 συναναμίγνυμι, G1788 ἐντρέπω

Reasoning. The command 'take note of' (semeiousthe) and 'do not associate with him' (me synanamignysthai auto) carry the explicit purpose 'that he may be put to shame' (hina entrape) and so brought to repentance. 'Put to shame' (entrepo) (9 occurrences) regularly means to shame into a change of conduct, so the corrective design of the social separation is stated in the text itself.

2Thess.3.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3560 νουθετέω, G0080 ἀδελφός

Reasoning. The qualifying clause 'yet do not regard him as an enemy but admonish him as a brother' (kai me hos echthron hegeisthe alla noutheteite hos adelphon) fences the separation against hostility. 'Admonish' (noutheteo) (8 occurrences) means corrective admonition, so the disciplined person remains within the scope of restorative correction, confirming the aim is recovery rather than permanent rejection.

1Tim.1.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3860 παραδίδωμι

Reasoning. The verb 'I handed over to Satan' (paredoka to Satana), applied to Hymenaeus and Alexander, governs 'that they may be disciplined not to blaspheme' (hina paideuthosi me blasphemein). The same hand-over verb and a 'discipline' (paideuo) purpose clause repeat the corrective intent of 1 Corinthians 5:5, reinforcing that exclusion aims at instruction.

Titus.3.10 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3868 παραιτέομαι

Reasoning. The instruction 'reject a divisive person after a first and second warning' (hairetikon anthropon meta mian kai deuteran nouthesian paraitou) again stakes a final action on prior graded warnings. 'Reject' (paraitomai) (12 occurrences) carries a range from excuse oneself to decline or reject, and the object plus the 'after a first and second warning' (meta mian kai deuteran nouthesian) phrase fix the sense here as refuse further fellowship, paralleling the final step in Matthew 18 and 1 Corinthians 5.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.5.13	1Cor.5.1	tsk	1
1Cor.5.5	1Cor.5.13	tsk	1
1Cor.5.11	1Cor.5.1	tsk	1
1Cor.5.8	Exod.12.15	tsk	1
2Thess.3.15	Lev.19.17	tsk	1
Matt.18.17	Matt.6.7	tsk	1

Complicating texts

2Thess.3.15 · addressed

The clause 'not as an enemy but admonish as a brother' (me hos echthron alla noutheteite hos adelphon) could be read as forbidding any formal exclusion. At the level of the words it does not, because 'but' (alla) coordinates with and qualifies the manner of the already commanded 'do not associate' (me synanamignysthai) rather than cancelling it. The separation stands but is bounded by ongoing admonition, which is exactly the proposition's stated aim to provoke repentance.

1Cor.5.10 · addressed

Paul clarifies 'not at all meaning the sexually immoral of this world' (ou pantos tois pornois tou kosmou toutou), distinguishing outsiders from a so-called brother. This confines the removal to the gathered community and does not soften the 5:13 command against an insider, so it does not undercut the proposition.

Matt.18.17 · addressed

'As the Gentile and the tax collector' (hosper ho ethnikos kai ho telones) could be taken merely as a private change of attitude without any assembly action. The aorist (a completed past action) subjunctive 'refuses to hear' (parakouse) the assembly (tes ekklesias) requires the assembly to have already spoken corporately, and the parallel hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) command 'remove' (exarate) in 1 Corinthians 5:13 shows the canon reads this comparison as concrete corporate removal, resolving the ambiguity toward the proposition.

1Cor.5.13 · addressed

Because 'remove' (exairo) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) in the Greek New Testament its exact force cannot be triangulated from internal distribution alone. The reading is anchored instead in the recurring Hebrew expulsion formula it echoes ('purge the evil from your midst'), which is well attested across Deuteronomy and present in the corpus, so the single occurrence is interpretively secure rather than ambiguous.

Concordance traversed

G1808, G3878, G1482, G5057, G4874, G3860, G2219, G3560, G1788, G3868, G1577, G4205, G4593, G1496, G0727, G3366

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

No variant units were supplied in the bundle for the cited verses, and none of these anchors fall in the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15). The 1 Corinthians 5:13 reading 'remove' (exarate), an aorist (a completed past action) imperative, versus a future indicative (a simple statement about the future) does not change the directive force of removal, so any such variation is verdict-neutral. CBGM data (a method for analyzing textual variants) was not examined for these books, hence ecm-shadow (outside the critical-apparatus coverage window).

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

restorative_final_step: affirms · On this reading the action is final-in-process but aimed at recovery. The 'so that' purpose clauses (the hina clauses) in 1 Corinthians 5:5 ('that the spirit may be saved' (to pneuma sothe)), 2 Thessalonians 3:14 ('that he may be put to shame' (hina entrape)), and 1 Timothy 1:20 ('that they may be disciplined' (hina paideuthosi)), plus the 'admonish him as a brother' (noutheteite hos adelphon) of 2 Thessalonians 3:15, fix the goal as repentance and reinstatement, so exclusion is the last disciplinary step but not a permanent verdict. This represents the proposition's 'intended to provoke repentance' clause in its strongest form.

protective_final_step: affirms · On this reading the same action primarily guards the community. The leaven figure of 1 Corinthians 5:6-7 and the 'remove' (exairo) command read removal as purging corrupting influence from the body, matching the proposition's 'protect the assembly' clause. The two lenses are not rivals here; both purposes are stated in the text and the verdict holds on either.

non_codified_pattern: disputed · A minority reading notes that the vocabulary establishes a graded discipline culminating in exclusion but does not legislate one fixed universal procedure. Matthew 18 addresses a personal sin between brothers and 1 Corinthians 5 a public scandal addressed by apostolic directive; the words give two scenes of escalation, not a single codified sequence binding every case. On this lens the proposition's specific claim that exclusion is the final step of the Matthew 18 process overstates a procedural uniformity the texts do not spell out, though the underlying terminal-exclusion pattern is granted.

The Deuteronomic expulsion formula carried into the 1 Corinthians 5:13 hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'remove' (exairo) illustrates progressive revelation of a single covenant-community discipline principle. Reading Matthew 18:15-17, 1 Corinthians 5, 2 Thessalonians 3, 1 Timothy 1:20, and Titus 3:10 together by analogy of Scripture (the principle that clear passages explain less clear ones) yields a coherent final step with

both protective and restorative aims, while honestly noting the words describe a graded principle rather than one codified procedure.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Removal from fellowship and the shared table is described in the New Testament as an action taken when an insider refuses correction, reached after lesser graded steps, and certain texts attach to it stated aims of repentance and of guarding the community. Whether it constitutes the single fixed final step of one codified Matthew 18 sequence is the matter under examination.

The phrases 'final step of the Matthew 18 process' and 'intended to provoke repentance and protect the assembly' partly encode the conclusion in the stem. The lexical evidence independently supports the final-tier ordering in Matthew 18:15-17 (graded by the 'hear' (akouo) and 'refuse to hear' (parakouo) conditionals (if-then clauses)) and the dual purpose stated in the 'so that' purpose clauses (the hina clauses), so the verdict is derived on the original stem rather than the neutralized one. The one element the words underdetermine is whether a single fixed procedure is in view, which is why a non_codified_pattern lens is recorded.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.5.13
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.18.17
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Cor.5.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1808
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3878
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4874
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.5.13
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License audit

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Flags

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